

Task 2

Case Study on the Formulation of Paracetamol Tablets

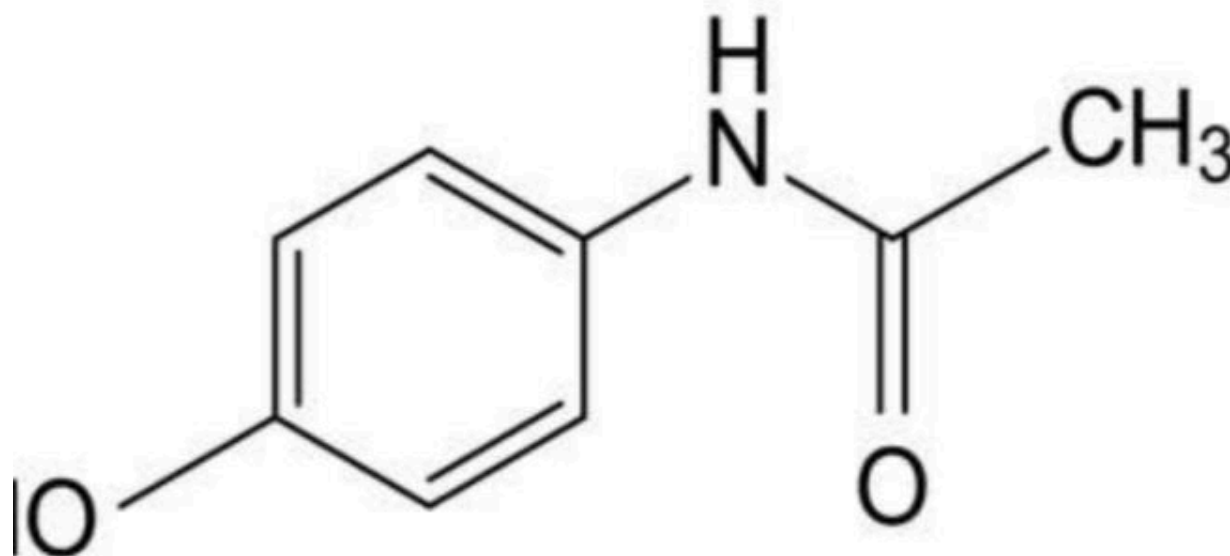
Submitted by: Shaista Sher

Program: BS Biotechnology

Internship: CodeAlpha Pharmaceutical Biotechnology Internship

1. INTRODUCTION

Paracetamol (Acetaminophen) is one of the most widely used analgesic and antipyretic drugs for the treatment of mild to moderate pain and fever. It is recommended for conditions such as headaches, toothaches, muscle pain, osteoarthritis, and fever associated with viral or bacterial infections. Due to its proven efficacy, safety at therapeutic doses, and affordability, paracetamol has been included in the World Health Organization (WHO) Model List of Essential Medicines. Among its various dosage forms, tablets are the most commonly prescribed because they are convenient to administer, provide accurate dosing, are easy to manufacture, and have a long shelf life.



Paracetamol

The formulation of paracetamol tablets requires careful selection of excipients and an optimized manufacturing process to ensure product quality, stability, and therapeutic effectiveness. Every step, from raw material selection to final packaging, must comply with Good Manufacturing Practices (GMP) and pharmaceutical quality standards.

2. FORMULATION PROCESS

The formulation process begins with the accurate weighing of the active pharmaceutical ingredient (API), paracetamol, and all required excipients according to the approved formulation. The ingredients are then blended thoroughly to ensure uniform distribution of the drug throughout the powder mixture. Depending on the manufacturing method, either wet granulation or direct compression is used.

In the wet granulation method, a binder solution is added to the powder mixture to form granules. These granules are dried under controlled conditions to remove excess moisture and then milled to obtain a uniform particle size. Lubricants and glidants are added before the granules are compressed into tablets using a tablet compression machine. In some formulations, a protective film coating is applied to improve the tablet's appearance, mask taste, reduce moisture absorption, and make swallowing easier.

After manufacturing, the tablets undergo quality control tests, including weight variation, hardness, friability, disintegration time, dissolution rate, and assay of the active ingredient. Only tablets that meet pharmacopeial specifications are packaged in blister packs or high-density polyethylene (HDPE) containers.

3. EXCIPIENT USE

Excipients are inactive ingredients that play a critical role in the formulation and performance of paracetamol tablets. Although they do not produce therapeutic effects, they ensure the quality, stability, and manufacturability of the final product.

Common excipients include:

- Microcrystalline Cellulose (MCC): Used as a diluent and dry binder to improve tablet strength and compressibility.
- Pregelatinized Starch: Functions as a binder and disintegrant, helping maintain tablet integrity while allowing rapid disintegration after administration.
- Croscarmellose Sodium: A superdisintegrant that promotes rapid tablet breakup in the gastrointestinal tract.
- Magnesium Stearate: Acts as a lubricant to reduce friction between the tablet and the compression equipment.
- Colloidal Silicon Dioxide: Improves powder flow properties and ensures uniform tablet weight.
- Film-Coating Agents (optional): Enhance appearance, improve stability, and protect the tablet from moisture and environmental factors.

The appropriate selection and concentration of these excipients significantly influence the tablet's quality, dissolution profile, and patient acceptability.

4. STABILITY FACTORS

The stability of paracetamol tablets is influenced by several environmental and manufacturing factors. Exposure to excessive moisture, heat, or direct sunlight may reduce the drug's potency and affect its physical appearance. Therefore, tablets should be stored in a cool, dry place at controlled room temperature and protected from humidity.

Proper packaging plays an essential role in maintaining product stability. Blister packs and tightly sealed containers minimize moisture uptake and protect the tablets during transportation and storage. Pharmaceutical companies also perform accelerated and long-term stability studies according to International Council for Harmonisation (ICH) guidelines to determine the product's shelf life and ensure its quality throughout the storage period.

5. FORMULATION CHALLENGES

Despite its simple composition, the formulation of paracetamol tablets presents several pharmaceutical challenges. The active ingredient has relatively poor compressibility, making tablet production difficult without suitable excipients. Achieving uniform distribution of the API, maintaining optimal tablet hardness, controlling friability, and ensuring rapid disintegration require careful optimization of the formulation.

Another challenge is protecting the tablets from moisture during manufacturing and storage, as excessive humidity can affect product quality. Manufacturers address these challenges through optimized formulation design, advanced manufacturing technologies, strict environmental controls, and comprehensive quality assurance procedures.



6. CONCLUSION

Paracetamol tablets remain one of the most successful pharmaceutical formulations because of their effectiveness, safety, affordability, and ease of manufacture. The formulation process involves the careful selection of excipients, optimized manufacturing techniques, and rigorous quality control to ensure consistent product quality and therapeutic efficacy. Proper storage conditions and stability monitoring further guarantee that patients receive safe and effective medication throughout the product's shelf life. This case study highlights the importance of

pharmaceutical formulation in developing high-quality oral dosage forms that meet international regulatory and quality standards.

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